

Meet the Mushers: Interviews with Atlla, Jonrowe, Sled Builders

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Keeping your dogs
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SUMMER



George Atlla settles back in a chair at the kitchen table of his home in North Pole, Alaska. It's spring and the end of yet another season of racing sled dogs.

"Now it's time to pay the bills," he says as he swings a thin arm toward a small mountain of envelopes on the table. On the counter, a two-quart coffee pot stands at the ready to fill his ever-emptying cup. A pack of cigarettes that won't survive the afternoon lies within reach. His 5-year-old son Frankie and 3-year-old daughter Sissy play in the television room, where Sesame Street blares in the background.

Atlla has just returned from spring carnival in Hughes, where he won a sled dog race and once again enjoyed the village hospitality here members from growing up in Huslia.

"It's really a good way to finish out the year," he says. "They make you feel special." Atlla, who turns 61 this August, has enjoyed a hero's welcome in the villages and elsewhere since his surprise win at the 1958 Fur Rendezvous World Championship in Anchorage. He matched that feat nine more times and won the Open North American Championship in Fairbanks eight times to earn his status as a speed mushing legend.

Dressed comfortably in jeans and a worn purple shirt, Atlla sits directly below a photograph taken of him at the Fur Rendezvous in 1958. He was 24 then, with chiseled, handsome features, a crop of thick, black hair and a hungry stare.

Today, the peaks and valleys of his face are somewhat hidden by his salt-and-pepper goatee and tinted glasses. The hungry stare has softened, and Atlla admits that he lost the inner fire behind the race years ago. His eyes instead reflect a contentment, especially when they fall upon Frankie and Sissy, his children with Tamara Ostlund.

As he taps a curling worm of ash off his cigarette, Atlla's mind races back 36 years as he's asked to recall his early days:

How do you think the George Atlla of 1958, just coming out of Huslia, would do today?

"I think I'd be very competitive. Back then, there was nothing that could stop me. If you were in my way back then, I'd find a way around you somehow, one way or another.

Were the village dogs you had in 1958 tougher than dogs are today?

"The dogs we had then used to run until they'd actually pass out. When you had one in the basket, it was passed out, it blacked

out somehow. [Today], these dogs got so much life when they go down—they're actually quitting, saying, 'The hell with you'—that you can't get them in the sled bag.

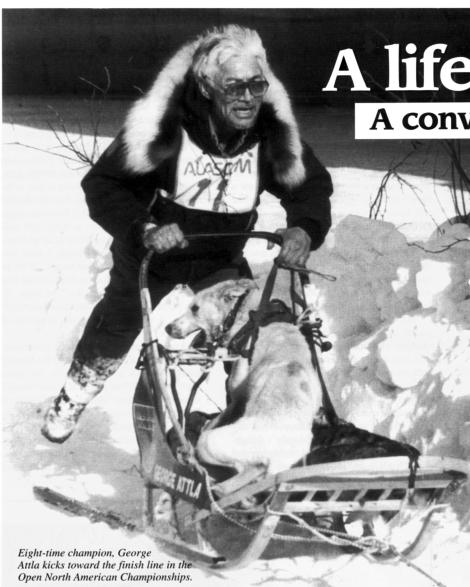
But years ago when I started, if they told me to load one inside a bag, it wouldn't have been any problem. But now the dogs are giving up. They're not able to hurt and run like the dogs we had back then.

Do you think it's harder to be competitive today with all these other mushers taking it on full time?

"Yeah. There's more teams that are up to win than there used to be, but it isn't that the mushers today have more desire. We had as much desire back then, but there are more of them because it's a business now.

What are the biggest changes from back in the fifties?

"The mushers themselves. It's a serious business now. Back then, we'd have a good time together. All the mushers would get



Eight-time champion, George Atlla licks toward the finish line in the Open North American Championships.

LISA B. FALLGREN STIVINS

together and have dinner and things like that before the race. We don't have that today. The mushers of today don't communicate like the mushers used to back then.

What do you think of the people who are dominating [the spirit circuit] today?

"Every kennel has its peak. Every kennel, no matter whose it is, is gonna peak somewhere along the years. You've been hearing a lot about the Champaines for half a dozen years now, but they were probably racing dogs 20 years before that. It took a while to get there, but they got there. Every major kennel does that somewhere along the line. It stands to reason. It's like you paid your dues.

You seem to have peaked several times. I've been lucky, and I've gotten ahead of a lot of good dogs for a lot of years, and that's kind of unusual.

"It's hard to be really competitive today. To go out and get it. I mean, you look at Ross

and you know he's out to win. It's hard for an older man—you can't get to that stage. You've passed that stage of being that hungry. You want to win, but you don't have that kind of drive anymore.

What's that kind of drive like?

"For instance, if you throw Rocky [Wright-Champaine] a nail and told her, 'Let's try to eat this nail,' she won't hesitate for a minute—she'll start chewing on the nail. That's what it's all about—just winning, going out and doing it. You want to do it. To have that kind of a drive, you can't do it when you're 60.

Sure, I can win if I had the dogs, but I couldn't do it with the team that was equal to Ross's and compete with him. Ross would beat me, no matter how smart I am.

Why's that?

"Because he has the hunger to do it. He has the wanting. He's willing to hurt for it. You tell Ross, 'I'll cut off your feet and you can have the North American.' He'll say, 'Cut my feet off.' But you ask me the same question, and I'll say, 'No, don't touch my feet, it'll hurt.'"

"There's no sport in the world that has a 60-year-old champion that I know of, even a 50-year-old. No physically competitive sport. Because there's a certain amount of hurt that goes into each winning.

You mean physical hurt?

"Physical hurt, and maybe you're sacrificing things to be able to get to that certain point.

What have you sacrificed before that you're not willing to sacrifice now?

"A lot of family life. I think I was away mushing dogs when I should have been home, but was willing to give all that up to be able to win. You take a guy like me, I'm too goddamned smart now to sacrifice anything.

How long has it been since you've felt 'the hunger'?

"Oh, God, probably 20 years [laughs]. I've won races after that, out of different things. Like Eddy [Streeter, who said Atlla was washed up in 1985, only to watch Atlla take the North American in 1986 and 1987] got me mad, and that gave me the drive. You get to a certain age and somebody has to throw a switch somewhere to make you go.

A lifetime in mushing

A conversation with George Atlla

BY NED ROZELL

[Saunderson] today, and you know he's out to win. It's hard for an older man—you can't get to that stage. You've passed that stage of being that hungry. You want to win, but you don't have that kind of drive anymore.

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If I get a good enough team, I can win again, but it won't be the same way I won 40 years ago.

With that hunger gone, what kind of edge do you have?

"I have a lot of advantages just from the knowledge I have. It's easy for me to read a dog. I call it 'talking' to a dog. I can look at a picture of a dog team and tell you what that

"That's what it's all about—just winning, going out and doing it."

dog team is thinking and how they're being handled just by their body language.

Driving dogs is a mental thing, and you have to be able to read the animal and know what he's thinking.

For someone who's tasted victory as many times as you have, what does it feel like to run in the North American and not do well or go into the Randy and finish in the lower half of the pack?

"It doesn't bother me at all [laughs]. And that's the bad part. I should've shaved my head or something after this winter. At my age it doesn't bother me. And it should be bothering me. For me to be a winner, it has to bother me.

When I was winning, when I was just really out to get it, I'd get so high that after it was over, whether I won or lost, I really got mentally depressed. You're so high on it, you couldn't bear people talk.

But now, it's just another race. It doesn't bother me at all—[which is terrible]. I think I know what it takes to win, and if it doesn't bother me to finish in the bottom half of the pack...those kind of guys don't win.

Do you ever think of retirement?

"Yeah, it won't be long. At the moment, five years. Because at my age, if you have to stop on the trail [to untangle dogs, etc.], you're not moving fast enough to win the race. You're actually defeating your own purpose if you have to move away from your sled.

Do you think you've slowed down the last few years?

"Oh yeah, I've slowed down a lot. I have

to watch my moves more carefully. A lot of times [the dogs] pull the hook while you're out there [tending to a dog]; you're standing still, and the sled shoots by at 20 miles an hour, and you grab it. Those days are coming to a close [laughs]. Anytime you start popping muscles pulling your self back up [which happened to Atlla's shoulder three years ago], things are not quite right.

How would you assess your present team?

"I think it's improving, but I'm a long way from having a top team. They don't seem to have the toughness they should have.

"I'm really good on leaders right now, but that's almost all I have—I don't have a team. I've got maybe half a dozen dogs on my team that could go into a winning team, and that's including the leaders.

There's some kennels you can look at and say that if they stay with that same breed of dogs, they're not going to win no matter how bad they want to. They're missing something. My kennel is like that. There's a point where your breeding has reached a

peak, and then your kennel starts going down. But, you're 'kennel blind,' and you keep breeding the same stuff.

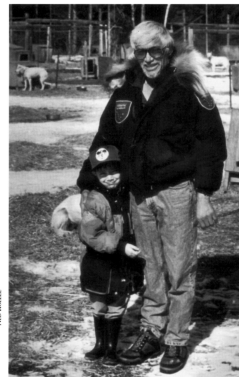
What's the main challenge for you to improve your team?

"Buy a lot of dogs. I've been here two days [from Hughes], and I picked up eight already.

If you're going to be competitive, if

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Atlla with his 5-year-old son, Frankie.



WILL BROWN

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you're going to bring your team up, there's no other way of doing it. You can't raise dogs fast enough. I've got a whole bunch of females bred, but that's two years away.

When you buy a dog, say a 3-year-old, how does it adapt to you?

"Dogs take to me really well. A dog would run for me that won't run for other people. I've never ever had a dog refuse to run for me. There's certain kennels that lease dogs out and they won't work for other people. I could take those dogs and they'd work for me.

Why?

"I don't know. For one thing, they have to

feel comfortable; they have to feel good with you. That has to be your first approach. You know, 'You're at a new home, but you're going to be okay.'"

It takes me longer to understand them, their strengths and things like that, than it takes for them to adjust to me. I'm probably slower than they are.

Are you gunning for an 11th World Championship at the Rendezvous to cap your career?

"It would be nice, but I've done my thing, and I'm satisfied. People think it would be nice to win and quit, but the way I think about it, I've already won. I've done my

thing better than anyone else will ever be able to do. Whether I go out winning or losing it wouldn't make no difference because I'm already a winner. There's no way anybody will ever make me a loser because I've been there and back already.

"I don't have nothing to prove. I don't have to go out a winner because I'm already a winner. Within my own self, I'm a winner.

Now, I'm enjoying myself.

Ned Rozell of Fairbanks, Alaska, is a freelance journalist and occasional contributor to MUSHING.